

Protecting Your Mental Health From Racism

Recognizing racial trauma and protecting yourself

4 psychology approaches · tips & resources — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Recognizing racial trauma and protecting yourself

Living with racism — insults, microaggressions, discrimination, constant hypervigilance — wears down and damages mental health: this is called racial trauma. It's not 'in your head': it's a real response to real aggression.

This guide helps you recognize it, protect your mental health, and heal.

Your intention

How racism weighs on your mood / energy right now: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Racial trauma is real

Hypervigilance, exhaustion, anxiety, anger, sometimes shame: the accumulation of racist experiences wears down body and mind, like slow weathering. It's not a weakness.

Naming this trauma means no longer blaming yourself for it.

Example

Exhausted without knowing why, Sami realized the build-up of microaggressions had worn him down in silence. Naming it relieved him.

My signals

What signs of fatigue/wear tied to racism do you notice (sleep, irritability, anxiety...)?

It's not a weakness

Write: 'My exhaustion is a normal response to real aggression.'

→ *Racial trauma is real — it's not a weakness.*

The thoughts that set in

'I must stay on guard', 'no one will believe me', 'maybe I'm exaggerating': this doubt is often installed by racial gaslighting (when what you live is denied).

Challenging it restores trust in your own perception.

Example

Told she was 'exaggerating', Nia doubted herself. Recognizing racial gaslighting gave her clarity back.

Doubt journal

Note: a thought that makes you doubt your experience · what's real in what you lived.

I believe my experience

Write: 'What I feel is valid — I'm not exaggerating.'

→ *I believe my own experience — I'm not exaggerating.*

Treating yourself gently

Your anger and fatigue are legitimate. You have the right to protect yourself, to rest, and to put your health before performance or educating others.

Your rest and your joy aren't a luxury — they're resistance.

Example

By allowing herself moments of pure joy and rest, Léa regained energy to keep going, without guilt.

My gentleness toward myself

Write 3 ways to take care of yourself when racism weighs on you.

Joy as resistance

What moment of joy / respite can you give yourself this week, without guilt?

→ *Protecting myself and finding joy — that's resistance too.*

Protecting yourself & healing

Concretely: limit exposure (media, toxic spaces), cultivate spaces of respite and joy, lean on community, set limits, and — if the weight is heavy — see a therapist who understands racism.

You don't have to absorb everything or explain everything.

Example

By reducing her exposure to violent content and finding a therapist who 'got it', Fatou saw her anxiety drop sharply.

My protections

Note: an exposure to reduce · a space of respite to cultivate · a limit to set.

My support

Whom to turn to if the weight gets too heavy (a loved one, community, a pro who understands)?

→ *Limit, recharge, surround myself — and seek help if needed.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Racial trauma is real — it's not 'in your head'.
- Spot your signals (exhaustion, hypervigilance, irritability, anxiety).
- Protect your energy: you don't have to absorb everything or explain everything.
- Cultivate spaces of respite and joy (Black joy and rest are acts of resistance).
- Surround yourself with community; set limits with toxic people/content.
- If the weight is heavy, seek a professional who understands racial experience.

To fill in

My signals & protections

Sign of wear	What I put in place

My recharge

Space of respite / joy	My support

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Recognize racial trauma in me.

Week 2 — Challenge the installed doubt (racial gaslighting).

Week 3 — Treat myself gently (respite, joy).

Week 4 — Protect myself & seek support.

Your plan in 3 lines

- The signal I watch:
- My space of respite / joy:
- My support if it gets heavy:

TO CLOSE

Racial trauma is real — protecting and resting yourself is resistance.

Protecting and resting yourself is resistance.

The racism, anti-Blackness and misogynoir you experience are real: this guide never minimizes them or asks you to adapt to the unacceptable. It's a coaching and psychoeducation tool to rebuild — not therapy. If you're going through a hard time, reach out to a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.